

# How to Refer a Client Suspected of an Eating Disorder



One of the most difficult conversations that a Nutrition Coach might have with a client is when a referral to a medical professional is warranted. Nutrition Coaches should spend some time preparing for the conversation to ensure empathy and support are conveyed. This should be a client-centered approach which might take more than one session to complete. Some clients might feel intimidated or embarrassed if the topic of referring out to another person is brought up, so coaches should approach these conversations with kindness, but also staying true to their scope of practice. The goal is to have a discussion that reveals some options based on information being shared, or behaviors that have been observed.

## *Some points to consider:*

- Use active listening to acknowledge and confirm what the client is sharing.
- Let the client know that you want to be as helpful and supportive as possible while remaining within your scope of practice.
- Explain what it means to remain within scope of practice.
- Clarify your role by discussing what a Nutrition Coach can and cannot do when certain thoughts about food or behaviors are present.
- Reassure the client that you have their best interest in mind and that you care about their overall wellbeing.
- Explain the benefits of including another specialist to collaborate with for appropriate nutrition coaching.
- Let the client know you often work with specialized health care providers when additional expertise is needed.
- Ask the client if they'd be willing to bring this up to their physician, or if they are interested in a referral to someone in the area who has an expertise in diagnosing and treating eating disorders. For example, ask the client what their thoughts are about including another professional to ensure the best strategies are in place.
- Be prepared to share resources.